
What We Found So Far

Results from the Ancestry Project

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Introduction

A family tree makes every relationship look roughly alike. Two names are connected by a line; another generation appears above them; the tree grows. The records behind those lines are not nearly so even. One branch may be supported by linked birth and marriage registrations. Another may rest on a household reconstructed from several censuses. A third may contain two people who resemble each other in half a dozen ways and still cannot responsibly be treated as one person.

This paper presents the current results of an intensive family-history project. The work began with records I had collected by hand and expanded during a concentrated period of research in July 2026. It now covers four paired family branches: Weck–VanderWier and Anderson–Lulofs on my father's side, and Madsen–Majchrzak and McIntyre–Zoscsak on my mother's side. These are not equally complete, and I have not tried to make them look that way.

Three questions guided much of the work. The first was who Thomas McIntyre had been before his documented marriage and Michigan family life. His records disagree about his birthplace and middle initial, while a separate Thomas Clifford Brown appears in the right Canadian and Rhode Island contexts without a document joining the two identities. The second question came from a family story that the Anderson

surname had been acquired during migration with another family. The third was broader: where did the documented family lines originate, and what routes brought them to Michigan?

The project has produced several kinds of result. Some are ordinary documentary chains. Dutch civil records, for example, can move a family from Michigan to named villages and another parent generation with relatively little ambiguity. Other results are corrections: an address reread from an original census page, a same-name death certificate rejected by later evidence, or a passenger match undone by the preceding page. Still others are bounded unknowns. Finding two older Michael Weck households does not tell us which man was an ancestor, but it does show why the current parent assignment cannot stand. A failed death-index search does not tell us when someone died, but it can eliminate a candidate and narrow the years that remain.

I treat these as results because family history is not improved only by adding names. It is also improved by separating people who had been confused, retaining a plausible candidate without promoting it, and stating exactly which record would change the conclusion. The sections below therefore begin with what each branch now supports, then reconstruct how that picture emerged, and end where the evidence currently stops.

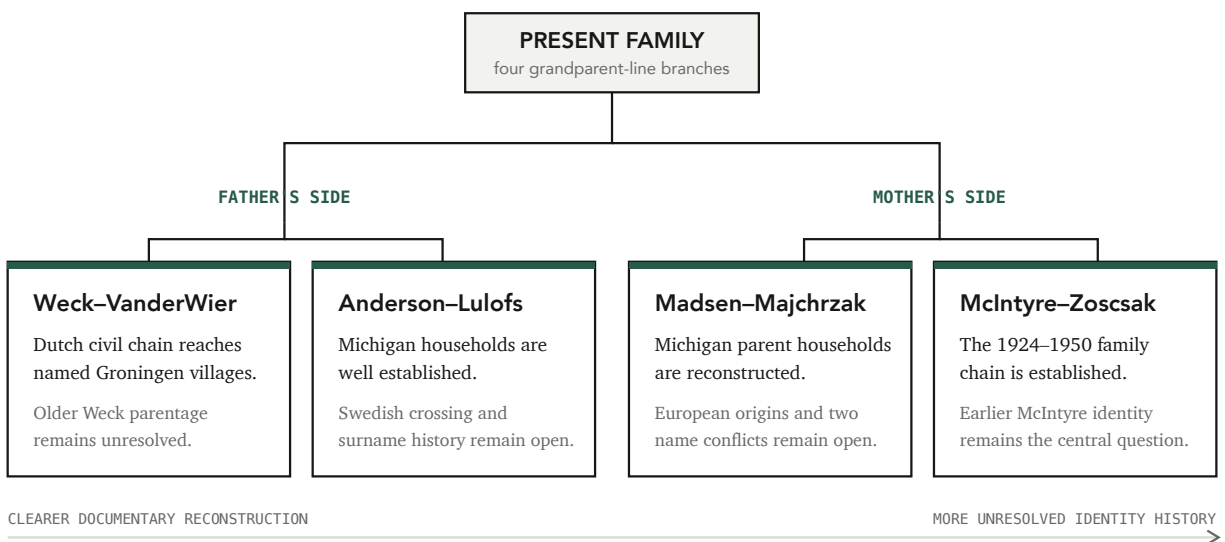


Figure 1. The four branch pairs used to organize the research results. The order keeps each parental side together while moving from clearer documentary reconstruction toward more unresolved identity questions.

Father's side

Weck-VanderWier

What we now know

The VanderWier side of this branch currently reaches farther into Europe than any other part of the project. Dutch civil records place Geert van der Wier's birth in Toornwerd, Groningen, in 1856 and Geeske de Vries's birth in De Waard in 1854. They married in Middelstum in 1879. Those records name Geert's parents as Jan Geerts van der Wier and Trijntje Jacobus de Maar, and Geeske's parents as Jacob de Vries and Lijsbert van der Leest. Later registrations add three younger children to Geert and Geeske's household after their son Jan: Jacob, Elibertus, and Mient, all born in Huizinge between 1882 and 1886.

The family's movement toward Michigan is also visible, although one important step remains incomplete.

An 1887 Groningen emigration register records Geert leaving Middelstum for Grand Rapids “to improve his livelihood.” A six-person De Wier party is indexed as arriving in New York on the *P. Caland* in May 1887. The sequence of the children's names is strikingly close to the Dutch household. Some names and ages are not. Because the original manifest has not yet been inspected, the project treats this as a strong passenger candidate rather than a completed crossing.

The Weck line has a different shape. It can be followed geographically from Washington County, Maryland, into Illinois and then Michigan, but the relationships become less certain as the records get older. Original census images place Charlotte Wick with Michael, John, and Henry in Maryland in 1850. By 1860, Maryland-born John, Henry, and Michael appear in nearby Illinois households. An official index records John Weck marrying Sophia Jay in Crawford County, Illinois, in 1864, and a cemetery transcription gives John's death in 1904. Later records connect the Illinois line to Byrl—also recorded as Burel, Burl, B. James, and James—Weck in Michigan.

What the evidence does not currently support is just as important. Public family-tree material had suggested that an older Michael Weck and Charlotte Edwards were John's parents. The original census records made that simple extension harder to defend. Washington County contains two different Michael Weck household heads in 1830. Neither household has the age structure expected if it simply contained the later John and the younger Michael as boys. The project therefore lowered the proposed father relationship instead of adding another generation. The Weck line is now source-backed in Maryland, but it does not yet have a verified European origin.

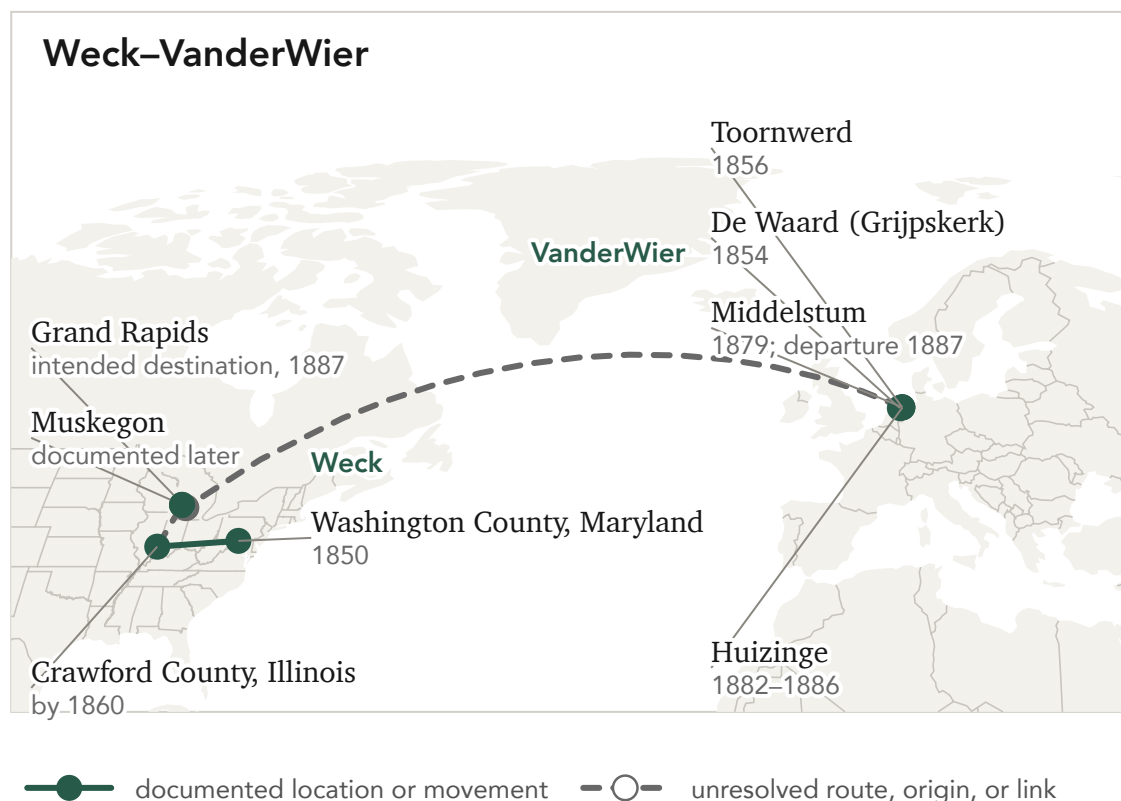


Figure 2. The Weck–VanderWier migration routes. Dutch records document the Groningen household and its 1887 destination, while the Atlantic crossing remains unresolved. The Weck cluster is documented from Maryland to Illinois; its later generational bridge to Muskegon remains unresolved.

How the picture emerged

This branch shows two very different kinds of progress. The Dutch records created a relatively clean chain. One civil record supplied parents, occupations, and a locality; the next supplied a marriage; additional registrations supplied children. Once the identity link from Michigan to Groningen was established, moving backward became ordinary record work. The uncertainty sits mainly at the Atlantic crossing, where the indexed *P. Caland* party still needs to be checked against the original page.

The Weck research became more useful by becoming less neat. Early indexes and public profiles made it possible to sketch a route from Illinois back to Maryland and then attach an older Michael as John's father. The first half of that route survived inspection. The parent assignment did not. The 1850 and 1860 census pages support a real cluster of Wick and Weck households moving from Maryland into Illinois. They do not state the relationships among those people. The two Michaels in 1830 then show why the distinction matters: a name, county, and plausible age were not enough to tell us which man later land and probate records might describe.

In other words, the result is not simply that the project found more ancestors. It found Geert and Geeske's Dutch families, and it found the point at which the Weck line had been extended too confidently. Those are different outcomes, but both improve the family history.

Where the evidence stops

The Dutch crossing needs the original *P. Caland* manifest and John or Jan VanderWier's naturalization record. Those records could confirm the passenger group, correct the damaged names, and connect the family's stated destination with its later Michigan life. One later parent relationship on this line—Anna Zielstra or Zylstra as Kathryn's mother—also remains under review pending a stronger parent-bearing record.

The Weck line stops at a cluster of Maryland households rather than a settled parent pair. The most useful next document is the 1830 deed recorded at Washington County Liber LL, folio 706. Tax lists, probate files, church records, and estate papers may separate the two older Michaels and identify their households. Until that happens, Charlotte has no established maiden name or spouse, neither Michael is accepted as John's father, and the family's origin before Maryland remains unknown.

Anderson–Lulofs

What we now know

The American part of the Anderson line is much clearer than the family story that first made it interesting. The 1884 Michigan state census records Victor Anderson, his wife Matilda, and sons Edwin and Charles together in North Muskegon. All four are recorded as born in Sweden. A second state census continues Victor and Charles in Laketon in 1894, and Charles's 1897 marriage return independently names his parents as Victor Anderson and Matilda Carlson. Residence-duration fields in the two censuses point to about 1880 as the family's arrival in Michigan and the United States. That is an approximate year, not a ship or port.

These records also put a limit on one version of the Anderson surname story. The story remembered in the family is that the Carlsons traveled with Anderson friends and were called Anderson during emigration or border processing. Whatever happened, the family was using Anderson in Michigan by 1884. Later records use the same surname for Charles and his descendants. A name change during Charles's later Michigan adulthood is therefore unlikely. The open question is earlier: what names did Victor, Matilda, and their children use in Sweden and during migration?

Passenger searches produced two useful candidates and one useful rejection. An 1880 Baltimore manifest contains a Sweden-born Victor Anderson of the right age, but the surrounding passengers do not reproduce the known family. An 1881 Philadelphia index contains a Sweden-born Matilda Anderson of the right age. When the preceding page was inspected, she appeared immediately after Jonas Anderson and was recorded

as a wife. That context made her a poor candidate for Victor's wife, and the project rejected the match.

The most interesting passenger group came from searching Swedish surname variants rather than Anderson alone. The same 1881 Philadelphia manifest contains Matilda Carlson, age forty, traveling with several children, including Carl Carlson, age ten. Those two entries fit Matilda and Charles unusually well. Victor and Edwin are missing, however, and three children in the passenger group do not appear in the accepted 1884 Michigan household. Searches for those children in Michigan led to other Carlson families, not to a confirming cluster. The candidate remains plausible, but it has not been accepted.

The Lulofs side is less dramatic and more settled. Florence Lorraine Lulofs's 1906 birth certificate names Louis Lulofs and Kate Smith as her parents. The 1910 census records Louis, Kate, Florence, and Helen in Grand Haven and reports that Louis's parents were born in the Netherlands. Florence's 1930 marriage license repeats Louis Lulof and Katherine Smith. Kate's 1936 death certificate identifies her father as Gerrit Smith, born in the Netherlands, and an 1894 Grand Haven census contains a Gerrit Smith household with a Michigan-born daughter Kate of the right age. An official index also records Louis Lulofs marrying Catherine Smith in 1904. The line is secure through Louis and Kate; their parents and exact Dutch origins are not.

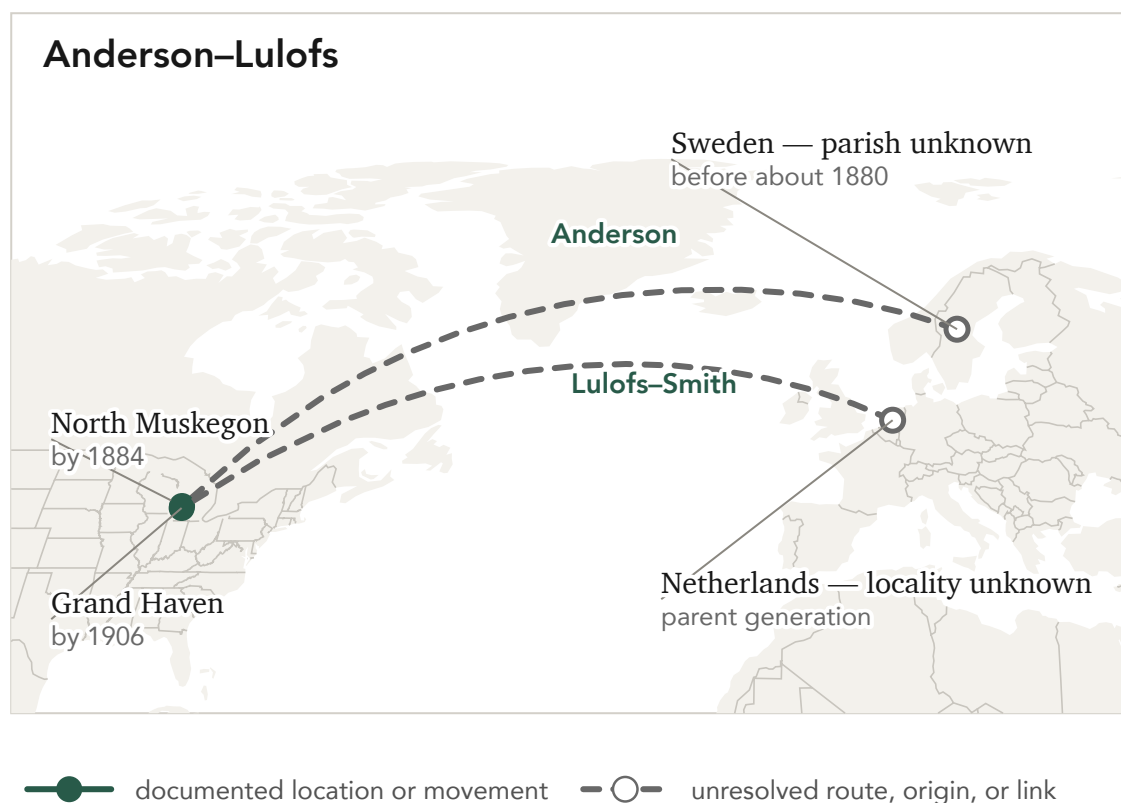


Figure 3. The Anderson-Lulofs migration routes. Both families are established in western Michigan, but their Swedish and Dutch origins remain broad because no accepted passenger or European household record yet completes either crossing.

How the picture emerged

Research on this branch began with recent Michigan records and moved backward one household at a time. Lee Anderson's obituary and death certificate led to Paul Anderson and Florence Lulofs. Their marriage and census records led to Charles Anderson and Ollie Peterson on one side and Louis Lulofs and Kate Smith on the other. Charles's marriage record then named Victor and Matilda, while the 1884 census supplied the

first accepted family group in Michigan.

Only after that household was established did the surname story become a research question rather than a free-floating family tale. The question is not simply whether “Anderson” was “really” another name. Swedish naming practices, the ordinary change from “Andersson” to “Anderson,” the transition from patronymics to inherited surnames, separate travel by family members, and informal or adoptive relationships can all produce parts of the remembered story. A literal borrowed-surname account would require a record that joins the same people across two names.

The passenger search sharpened the question without answering it. Looking at an indexed name alone produced an excellent-looking but wrong Matilda. Looking at the page around her revealed an apparent husband. Searching Carlson, Carlsson, Karlsson, and daughter-form variants produced the stronger Matilda-and-Carl group, but tracing the other passengers failed to connect it to Muskegon. The result is a smaller and better-defined search: Swedish parish and emigration records for a family of the right ages, not another broad hunt for an Anderson-shaped name.

The Lulofs work followed the more common pattern seen elsewhere in the project. Birth, marriage, census, and death records agreed on the immediate family. Similar Lulofs households in Muskegon were kept separate because their dates did not fit Florence's father. That restraint leaves the immigrant generation open, but it also prevents one Louis Lulofs from swallowing every other Louis in western Michigan.

Where the evidence stops

The Anderson line now stops at Sweden in the abstract. No parish, birth record, household examination, moving-out record, or emigration record has yet identified Victor, Matilda, Edwin, and Charles before arrival. Charles's or Victor's naturalization file may provide a birthplace, arrival date, ship, or former name. The Matilda Carlson and Carl Carlson passenger group remains a candidate until a Swedish or American record either joins it to the Michigan family or identifies it as another family.

The Lulofs line stops with Louis and Kate's parent clues. Louis's birth record and the original 1904 marriage record should identify his parents if the surviving forms contain the expected fields. Gerrit Smith is a strong working identification for Kate's father, but her mother's maiden name and the Smith family's Dutch locality remain unknown. At present, the records show Dutch parentage. They do not yet show the route from a particular Dutch family to Grand Haven.

Mother's side

Madsen–Majchrzak

What we now know

The Madsen household is now anchored by a combination of family knowledge and public records. The 1950 census records Everett R. Madsen and Mary B. Madsen in Eastlake with their daughters Darlene, Carole, and Ardis. Carole Slawinski's obituary independently names Everett and Mary as her parents and Darlene and Ardis as her sisters. Family knowledge supplies the direct link from Darlene to the present family and confirms that Ardis was also Mary's daughter.

Everett's parents were Hans Madsen and Ellen Dahlvig Madsen. Everett and Mary's 1932 marriage license names them directly, and the 1910 census records infant Everett in Hans and Ellen's Manistee Township household. Hans was born in Denmark and reported immigrating in 1892. Ellen was born in Sweden and reported immigrating in 1889. The household included eight living children: Peter, Elsie, Earl, Irma, Agnes, Leonard, Gladys, and Everett. Later records keep the family in East Lake, and the 1950 census records the widowed Hans living with his son Clayton.

This later census also settles one same-name question. A 1938 Manistee death certificate describes a Hans Madsen who was older, single, and associated with a different residence and occupation. At first it was simply a poor fit for Everett's father. Once the accepted Hans appeared alive in 1950, the 1938 man became chronologically impossible. He remains in the research as a rejected candidate so that his parents and dates are not accidentally imported later.

The best remaining Hans lead is an oral-history recording that the project has not yet heard. A university catalog describes a 1956 interview with Hans Madison, born in Denmark in 1874, who worked in Manistee-area mills and railroads. Those details fit well. The recordings are restricted, however, and the catalog alone is not enough to add "Madison" as another name or quote the interview as family history.

Ellen's 1933 death certificate gives a possible Swedish parent generation: John Peterson and Elsie Dahlvig, both born in Sweden. A cemetery memorial gives a different pair, John Dahlvig and Elsa Nelson Dahlvig. The disagreement is not cosmetic. It affects Ellen's maiden name and the identity of both parents. Exact-date searches in Swedish records produced three promising women, but each could be followed in Sweden after Ellen was established in Michigan. All three were rejected. Ellen's Swedish birth family remains unknown.

Mary's side reaches Thomas Majkszak or Majchrzak and Blanche Janowiak. The surname varies across records, as does Blanche's given name: other sources use Pelagia or Pelage. Mary's marriage license names Thomas and Blanche as her parents. An obituary for Mary's sister Philemonia Bartoszek independently names the same parents and explicitly places Mary in the sibling group. This makes the family relationship much stronger than a cemetery memorial by itself.

The remaining disagreement concerns a brother named Raymond or Ray. An original birth certificate records Raymond born on August 24, 1907. Later cemetery material records a son Ray born on August 24, 1914, in the same Thomas and Pelagia-Blanche family. The question is whether one source has the wrong year, whether two sons received the same name, or whether the cemetery transcription joined the wrong people. The project has not merged them.

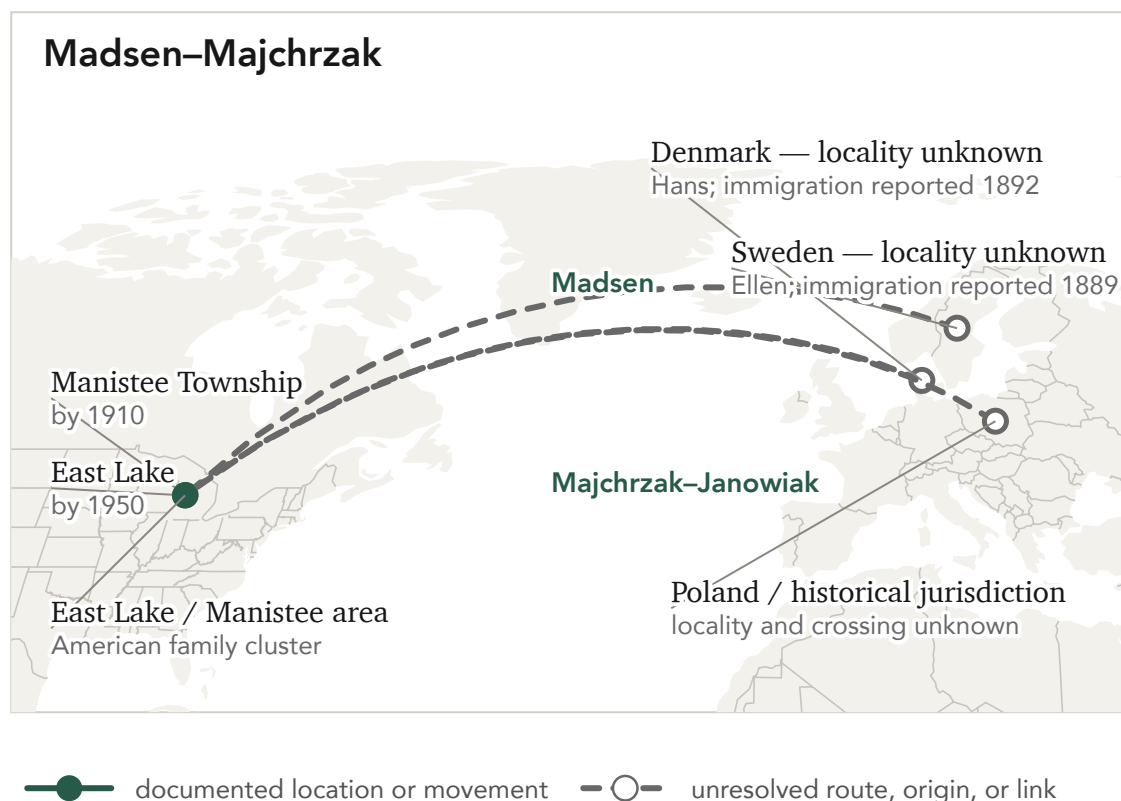


Figure 4. The Madsen–Majchrzak migration routes. Accepted households document movement within Michigan. The Danish, Swedish, and Polish crossings remain broad because exact European localities and arrival records have not been established.

How the picture emerged

This branch began with people I already knew and a relatively recent obituary. That did not make the older history automatic, but it gave the search a reliable household to work from. Carole's obituary led to Everett and Mary. The 1950 census placed the parents and three daughters together. The 1932 marriage license then named both sets of grandparents, and the 1910 census placed Everett in Hans and Ellen's large household.

The strongest discoveries often came through relatives beside the direct line. Philemonia's obituary mattered because it supplied a second route to Mary's parents. Clayton's 1950 household mattered because Hans was living there, which rejected the wrong death certificate. Earl's Wisconsin birthplace in the 1910 census shows that the family briefly moved outside Michigan, although it does not tell us where they lived in the 1900 census. These collateral facts do not automatically add ancestors. They make the direct line easier to test.

The research also produced an unusually promising source that is still only potential evidence. If the Hans Madison recording belongs to Everett's father, it may preserve his own account of migration and working life. Until the audio is heard, the project knows only what the catalog says. That distinction keeps an exciting lead from becoming a story written in advance of its source.

The Raymond question is a smaller version of the same discipline. Two records overlap on name, day and month, and family context but disagree on a seven-year span. The way forward is not to choose the date that fits the current tree more comfortably. Ray's death certificate and cemetery file may resolve it, and separate conversations with Darlene and Ardis may establish whether the family remembered one Raymond, two children, or a reused name.

Where the evidence stops

Hans still lacks an exact Danish birthplace, a verified arrival record, a naturalization file, and an original death record. Ellen lacks a Swedish parish, a reliable parent pair, and a documented emigration route. The possible 1956 oral history cannot contribute biographical facts until the recordings are obtained and the speaker is identified.

Mary's own birth, church, death, and obituary records remain important gaps. Thomas and Blanche or Pelagia have not been traced to a specific Polish town or historical jurisdiction, and their migration and naturalization histories are still open. The Raymond disagreement needs original death and cemetery records plus oral histories collected without first feeding relatives the competing dates.

McIntyre–Zoscsak

What we now know

The McIntyre side contains the question that originally drove much of this research: who was Thomas E., C., or Clifford McIntyre before he married Julia Zoscsak in Detroit in 1924? The difficulty is not simply that his name varies. His records alternate between Canada or Prince Edward Island and Rhode Island as his birthplace; the marriage record gives the middle initial E, while later records give C or Clifford; and no accepted record has yet placed him before 1924 under the McIntyre identity.

From the marriage forward, however, the family is much clearer. The 1924 return records Thomas E. McIntyre marrying Julia Josiak, a spelling of Zoscsak. In 1930, Thomas MacIntyre and Julia appear in the Detroit household of Julia's brother George Zoscsak. A Rhode Island census card records Thomas C. McIntyre with the same August 18, 1898 birth date later used on his draft card. The 1940 census places Thomas, Julia, and their children in Michigan and reports that the family had lived in rural Providence County in 1935. His 1942 draft card gives the fullest name and birthplace: Thomas Clifford McIntyre, born on Prince Edward Island. The 1950 census continues Thomas, Julia, and their son Donald in Stronach Township. Later obituaries independently identify Thomas Clifford or Thomas C. McIntyre and Julia Zoscsak as the parents of Donald and his siblings.

The project therefore treats the 1924 through 1950 appearances as one working person. That decision does not settle everything attached to him. The 1924 record names his parents as Thomas and Louise Broom, but the exact “Broom” spelling carries limited weight because other names on the same form were also misspelled. The Rhode Island birthplaces in the 1930 and 1940 censuses remain in conflict with the Canadian and Prince Edward Island readings elsewhere.

The Brown evidence is separate. It is not a collection of random near-matches. Records reconstruct a real family moving through Prince Edward Island, Providence, and briefly Detroit. A PEI baptism identifies Thomas Clifford Brown as a child in a John Brown and Louisa McIntyre family. A 1901 Canadian census and a 1915 Rhode Island census place Clifford with the Brown household. In 1918, draft cards record both Thomas Clifford Brown and his brother Joseph Willard Brown in Providence, working for Brown & Sharpe. Willard married in Providence, lived in Detroit with his wife and daughter in 1920, and later returned to Providence.

That cluster overlaps with Thomas McIntyre in ways that are difficult to ignore. Both men use Thomas Clifford. Both are connected to Canada or Prince Edward Island, Providence, a birth date around August 18 in 1898 or 1899, and machinist work. The Brown family itself carries McIntyre as the mother's surname. The conflicts are equally real. Thomas Clifford Brown was still using Brown in 1918, reported a wife named Millie, and has a chronology that does not simply collapse into the later Thomas and Julia household. No record currently says that Brown became McIntyre. The project keeps the two identities apart.

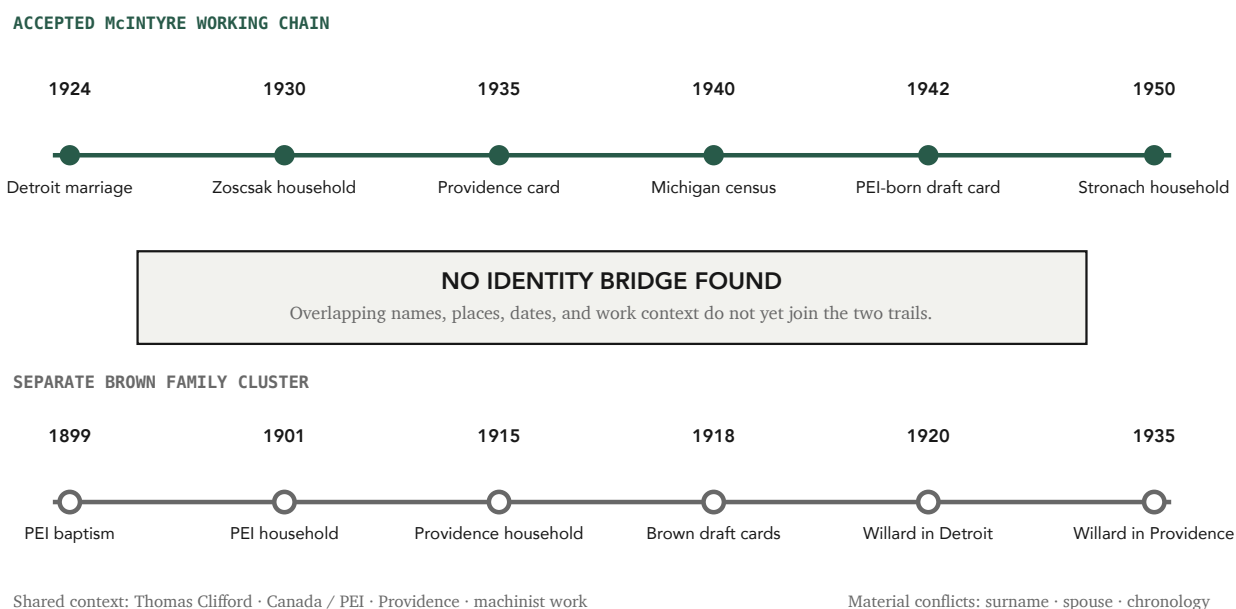


Figure 5. The accepted McIntyre record chain and the separate Brown family cluster. The records overlap in names, places, dates, and work context, but no source currently joins the two identities.

A recent family conversation added another name to this cluster. My mother remembers her father Donald referring to his own grandmother as “Grandma Hirsch.” Before that conversation, Providence records had already produced a Louise McIntyre, Louise Brown, and Louise Hirsch path. A marriage index records Louise Brown marrying Bernard Hirsch in 1923. A 1935 census card records Louise Hirsch in Providence. Her daughter Mary Ethel’s 1936 death certificate identifies the mother as Louise McIntyre and the informant as Mrs. Louise Hirsch.

The memory makes Hirsch much more relevant to Donald’s family history. It does not identify the woman. We do not yet know which side of Donald’s family she belonged to, whether “Grandma” described a biological or social relationship, or whether the Providence woman was the person he meant. The oral account is a result because it connects a remembered surname and generation to an existing documentary question. It is not yet an identity conclusion.

Searches for Louise’s later life have narrowed the possibilities without finding her death. Rhode Island’s digitized 1956–1966 death indexes contain no matching Louise or Louisa Hirsch or McIntyre. The only Louise Brown entry in that period was a different woman. An online family tree reportedly gives a 1957 death in Michigan, but it provides no visible evidence and has been wrong before. Michigan is worth checking because Willard Brown lived in Detroit, but the strongest verified later-life evidence for Louise remains in Providence.

The Zoscsak side is less developed, but several basic relationships are now firm. Julia’s delayed birth certificate records her birth in Mount Pleasant, Pennsylvania, in 1906 and names Joseph Zoscsak and Rosalia Gorlicky as her parents. A corrected reading of the 1920 census places thirteen-year-old Julia in Joseph’s household in Stronach Township. The 1930 Detroit census identifies George W. Zoscsak as Julia’s brother and Marie C. Sisco as George’s wife. Reinspection also corrected the household address from the earlier reading “Hazen” to 20429 Prairie and restored two children omitted from the first transcription. An Iowa birth index supports the Sisco surname and one son’s Iowa birthplace.

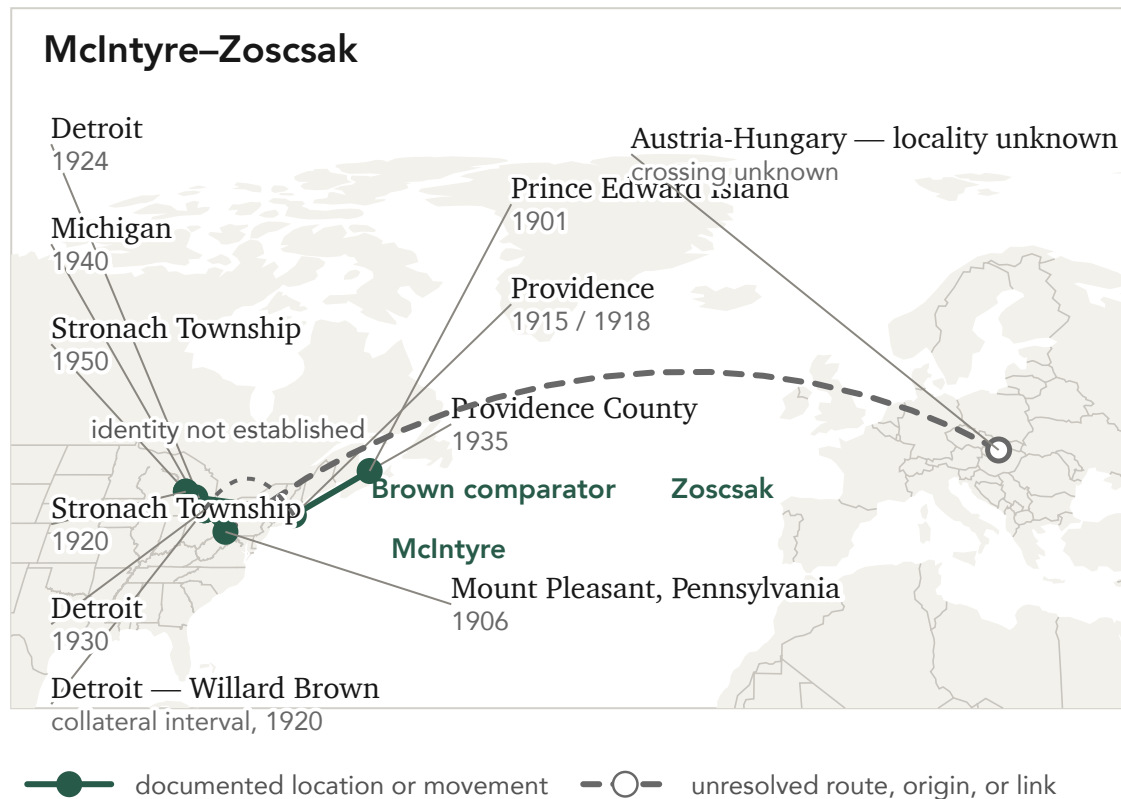


Figure 6. The McIntyre–Zoscsak migration routes. The post-1924 McIntyre chain and the American Zoscsak route are documented. Brown remains a separate comparator, and the dashed connector marks an identity question rather than an accepted movement.

How the picture emerged

I first assembled the basic Brown and McIntyre story by hand in 2024. The 2026 project did not begin with a blank slate, and it did not begin by asking an agent to invent a plausible story from names. It began by rebuilding that earlier account from the records and asking which parts of it survived when every appearance was kept attached to its source.

The Thomas McIntyre chain after 1924 survived. Marriage, census, draft, obituary, and family evidence all point to the same household, even while the middle initial and birthplace vary. The pre-1924 story did not become clearer at the same speed. Instead, the Brown research expanded sideways. PEI baptisms supplied parents and siblings. Providence censuses and draft cards rebuilt the household. Willard's Detroit census supplied a real connection to Michigan. Shared Brown & Sharpe employment made the brothers' Providence context more coherent. None of those records supplied the sentence the research still needs: that this Thomas Brown and the later Thomas McIntyre were the same man.

Some of the most useful results came from errors and ugly indexes. The 1915 Louise Brown household was found by searching first names because the surname had been mangled badly enough to resemble something else entirely. That household made the Brown family more concrete. On the Zoscsak side, rereading the original 1930 page corrected an address that had already sent research toward the wrong Detroit street. These are modest discoveries, but they change what later searches can find.

The “Grandma Hirsch” memory arrived only after the documentary Brown-to-Hirsch path had been built. That sequence matters. Without the records, the phrase would be a family memory with no clear route

forward. With them, it suggests specific questions for another conversation and specific records to request. It still does not authorize a merge.

This branch has therefore accumulated a great deal of evidence without settling its central identity question. That is not failure disguised as sophistication. We now know much more about the Brown family, much more about Thomas and Julia after 1924, and more about the Louise Brown/Hirsch trail. We also know exactly where the connection among them remains conjectural.

Where the evidence stops

The decisive McIntyre records remain unacquired. Thomas and Julia's complete 1924 marriage file may clarify the parent names. Thomas's death certificate, alien-registration file, naturalization record, or any reissued birth record may identify his birthplace, parents, arrival, or former name. A verified document connecting Thomas McIntyre to the Brown household would change the project. Another record that merely resembles both men would not.

The Brown-to-Hirsch path needs the full 1923 marriage record and Louise's death, obituary, alien, probate, or cemetery records. The Rhode Island State Archives can search the non-digitized 1936–1955 death index. The 1957 Michigan assertion should not control the search unless the original online profile supplies a place or citation. Follow-up family conversations should begin by asking who “Grandma Hirsch” was, which side of the family she belonged to, and what else was remembered about her, rather than prompting anyone with the current theory.

The Zoscsak line needs Julia's original baptism, Joseph and Rosalia's immigration and naturalization records, and parent-bearing records for George. Their exact European towns are still unknown. The current evidence supports an Austria-Hungary-to-Pennsylvania-to-Michigan route in broad outline. It does not yet identify the modern country or locality from which the family came.

Results across branches

These four branches converge on Michigan, but they do not tell one migration story. The VanderWier line runs from named villages in Groningen toward Grand Rapids and Muskegon. The Weck records move from Maryland into Illinois and then Michigan, while the family's earlier origin remains unknown. The Anderson household appears in Muskegon County around 1880 after a still-unresolved Swedish crossing. The Lulofs and Smith records point to Netherlands-born parents in western Michigan without yet identifying the immigrant households. Hans and Ellen Madsen came from Denmark and Sweden into East Lake; the Majchrzak and Janowiak line points broadly toward Poland; the Zoscsak and Gorlicky line runs from Austria-Hungary through Pennsylvania into Michigan. The McIntyre and Brown records cross Prince Edward Island, Providence, Detroit, and northern Michigan, but the exact route depends on an identity connection the project has not established.

The difference among these branches is not simply that some received more research time. Different evidence produces different rates of progress. A Dutch birth registration names parents and a locality, which makes the next search comparatively clear. A census household supplies relationships, ages, and birthplaces that can be checked in another year. A disputed identity does not behave that way. Each new Brown record strengthened the Brown family reconstruction, but none necessarily made Brown into McIntyre. One difficult question can therefore remain open while several other branches grow by generations.

Original record context repeatedly changed what the project could say. The indexed Philadelphia passenger named Matilda Anderson and looked excellent until the preceding page revealed Jonas Anderson. The 1930 Zoscsak census address looked like Hazen until the image was reread as Prairie. A Manistee death certificate looked like a possible Hans Madsen until a 1950 census showed the relevant Hans still alive. Two Michael

Weck households in the same Maryland district turned one plausible father into two men who now have to be separated through land, tax, and probate records. These are not clerical footnotes. Each correction changes the people, places, or searches that follow from it.

Collateral relatives did much of the useful work. Philemonia Bartoszek's obituary gave independent support for Mary Madsen's parents. Willard Brown's records made the PEI-Providence-Detroit Brown route visible. Geert and Geeske's younger children made the *P. Caland* passenger group recognizable. George Zoscsak's household connected Julia to a sibling and supplied the address from which the Detroit trail can continue. Direct ancestry may be the organizing interest, but siblings, spouses, witnesses, neighbors, and travel companions often preserve the evidence that a direct ancestor did not.

Family memory also became more useful once it could be compared with records. The Anderson surname story generated a testable migration question rather than a conclusion. The remembered phrase "Grandma Hirsch" raised the importance of a documentary Brown-to-Hirsch path while leaving the woman's identity open. The conflicting Raymond dates produced specific questions for Darlene and Ardis. In each case, oral history changed what to look for. It did not replace the records needed to decide what happened.

The broadest result, then, is a family history with uneven resolution. Some lines now reach named European villages and parent generations. Some reach an American household but not the crossing before it. Some are held at a deliberate gap between two plausible identities. The common endpoint is not certainty. It is a clearer distinction between what the records establish, what they suggest, and what they have not yet answered.

Conclusion

The project has materially changed the family history I started with. The VanderWier line now reaches a documented household in Groningen. The Anderson family is established in Michigan by 1884, with a much narrower question about its Swedish names and migration. The Madsen and Majchrzak households now extend through parent generations supported by marriage, census, death, and collateral records. The Weck line has a defensible Maryland-to-Illinois route even though its oldest proposed father has become less secure. Julia Zoscsak's parents and sibling context are clearer. Thomas McIntyre's documented family life can be followed across several decades, while the Brown and Hirsch research has become a substantial family history in its own right.

The largest questions remain open. No Swedish parish has been identified for Victor and Matilda. No European origin has been established for the Wecks. Ellen Madsen's Swedish parents remain disputed. The Brown records still do not say that Thomas Clifford Brown became Thomas McIntyre. The Zoscsak line has only begun to move beyond its American households.

That is where the research stands: a larger and more precise account of the family, accompanied by a smaller and more precise set of unknowns. The tree has grown, but the more important result is that its unfinished edges now have names, records, and questions attached to them.